island. Sanghamitra is the protector of the plant in Sri Lanka, Tissarakkha its destroyer back home. The chronicle remembers the last years of Ashoka in relation to the divergence in the behaviour of his queens and the differing nature of their engagement with Buddhism. Asamdhimitta, his ‘dear consort’, was a faithful devotee of the Buddha and her death is the beginning of Ashoka’s end. Her place was taken, after an interregnum, by the beautiful but jealous Tissarakkha whose resentment of Ashoka’s devotion to the Buddha results in a protracted vengeance with the emperor passing away after four years. The evil queen’s ability to destroy something as sacred to the emperor as the Bodhi tree suggests that her husband was by then no longer the master of state affairs.